US likely to strike Iran in mid-November

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【メール原文】

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The US will likely strike Iran in mid-November

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The US is planning an intense, short campaign of airstrikes designed to degrade Iran’s military capabilities and force it to accept US demands.
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Iran will likely resist the pressure and mount an aggressive retaliation that could include non-energy infrastructural targets.
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Iran could target undersea cables running through the Strait of Hormuz, but Houthi attacks on Red Sea cables—which matter more internationally—are less likely because the Houthis want to avoid dragging the US into their war with Saudi Arabia.

US is likely to strike in mid-to-late November. The US is likely to launch new military strikes against Iran (65%), potentially with Israeli support (see: Hormuz attacks likely to compel US escalation after midterms , 15 October 2026). The US is unlikely to strike before the midterm elections, given the political downside and the need for additional time to prepare new strikes. It will likely act on existing plans for a short, high-intensity escalation in mid-November. A third aircraft carrier is scheduled to arrive in the Middle East toward the end of the month, but the US may choose to act before it is deployed.

The US strikes are likely to be brief and intense. As in late summer (see: Iran war escalation & energy implications , 29 July 2026), the US is contemplating a brief, intense round of airstrikes on strategic targets, including Iran’s underground missile and nuclear facilities. It will likely use strategic bombers and bunker-busting munitions. The US or Israel could also strike civilian and energy infrastructure. The strikes aim to weaken Iran, degrade its military capabilities, and pressure its leadership to accept US demands at the negotiating table.

Iran will resist the pressure and retaliate aggressively. Iran’s economic outlook is dire, but the regime is not prepared to submit to US pressure. Its military capabilities have proven resilient to US and Israeli military attack, and the leadership’s capacity to absorb pain remains considerable. Even if US bombing damages or entombs Iran’s missile stockpiles, Iran possesses large quantities of short-range missiles and drones that can be used against regional targets. Iran will keep retaliating as long as the US or Israel continues offensive operations.

A breakthrough in negotiations remains unlikely. Mediators remain active, but little progress has been made. The Mecca Agreement partners—Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan—visited Tehran on 26 October, likely to contain escalation risk by urging Iran to avoid attacking regional infrastructure in retaliation for new US strikes.

A minimal arrangement is possible. Iran would halt its attacks in the Strait of Hormuz and agree to begin new nuclear discussions (without making any up-front concessions). In exchange, the US would drop its blockade and permit Iran to export oil again. At the moment, however, a deal looks unlikely (20%) unless Iran accepts US demands on its nuclear program or the US drops those demands and agrees to a more limited arrangement focused on the strait.

Iran's retaliation will be aggressive and could target non-energy infrastructure. Iran will likely target US bases, military assets, and energy infrastructure if attacked. It has also signaled broader action against regional infrastructure, including undersea cables, AI infrastructure and data centers, desalination plants and electricity facilities, and airports and ports. The severity of the response depends on the scale of the US and Israeli strikes. Iran wants to deter further attacks, so its response will likely be more aggressive than in the past.

Kuwait, Qatar, and Bahrain are most exposed to cable strikes. Several major cables traverse the strait, putting them within reach of Iranian sabotage. Multiple Iranian officials have explicitly said undersea cables will be a target if Iran comes under attack again.

Kuwait, Qatar, and Bahrain depend most on these cables, so they face the greatest risk of disruption. Most Saudi links are in the Red Sea, and most UAE cable landings are in Fujairah on the Gulf of Oman, which gives both countries geographic resilience. Houthi attacks threaten Saudi Arabia's connectivity. Attacks on Red Sea cables are less likely, however, given the system's greater international importance and the Houthis' apparent desire to avoid escalating their conflict with Riyadh in a way that drags in the US (see: Houthis likely to avoid market-moving strikes on Saudi oil , 14 October 2026).

Gregory Brew
Senior Analyst, Iran & Energy
+1 646 259 3207
brew@eurasiagroup.net
Clayton Allen
Practice Head, United States
+1 202.903.0027
allen@eurasiagroup.net
Firas Maksad
Managing Director, Middle East & North Africa
+1 202.552.5384
maksad@eurasiagroup.net
Marc Gustafson
Managing Director, Analysis
+1 202.540.5144
gustafson@eurasiagroup.net

Cliff Kupchan
Chairman Emeritus & Senior Advisor
+1 202.903.0013
kupchan@eurasiagroup.net
Scott Bade
Senior Analyst, Geo-technology
+1 202.540.5140
bade@eurasiagroup.net
EG Middle East & North Africa
mena@eurasiagroup.net

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